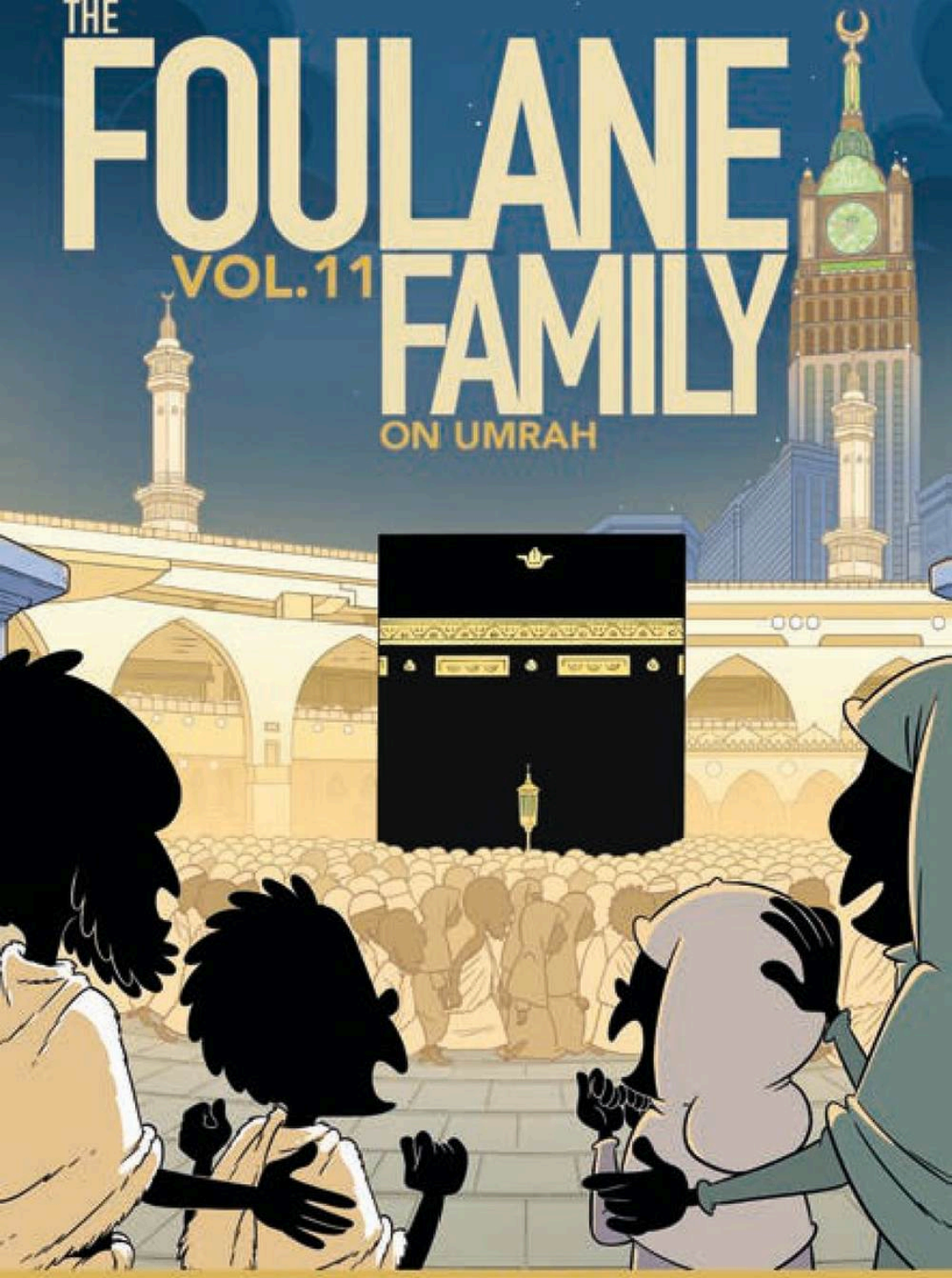
THE FOULANE FAMILY

VOL. 11

ON UMRAH



PART 2: MAKKAH

Vol 11 On a journey to Mecca!
Family Umrah

THE FOULANE FAMILY

Written and illustrated by
Norédine Allam
Editorial Director
Karim Allam

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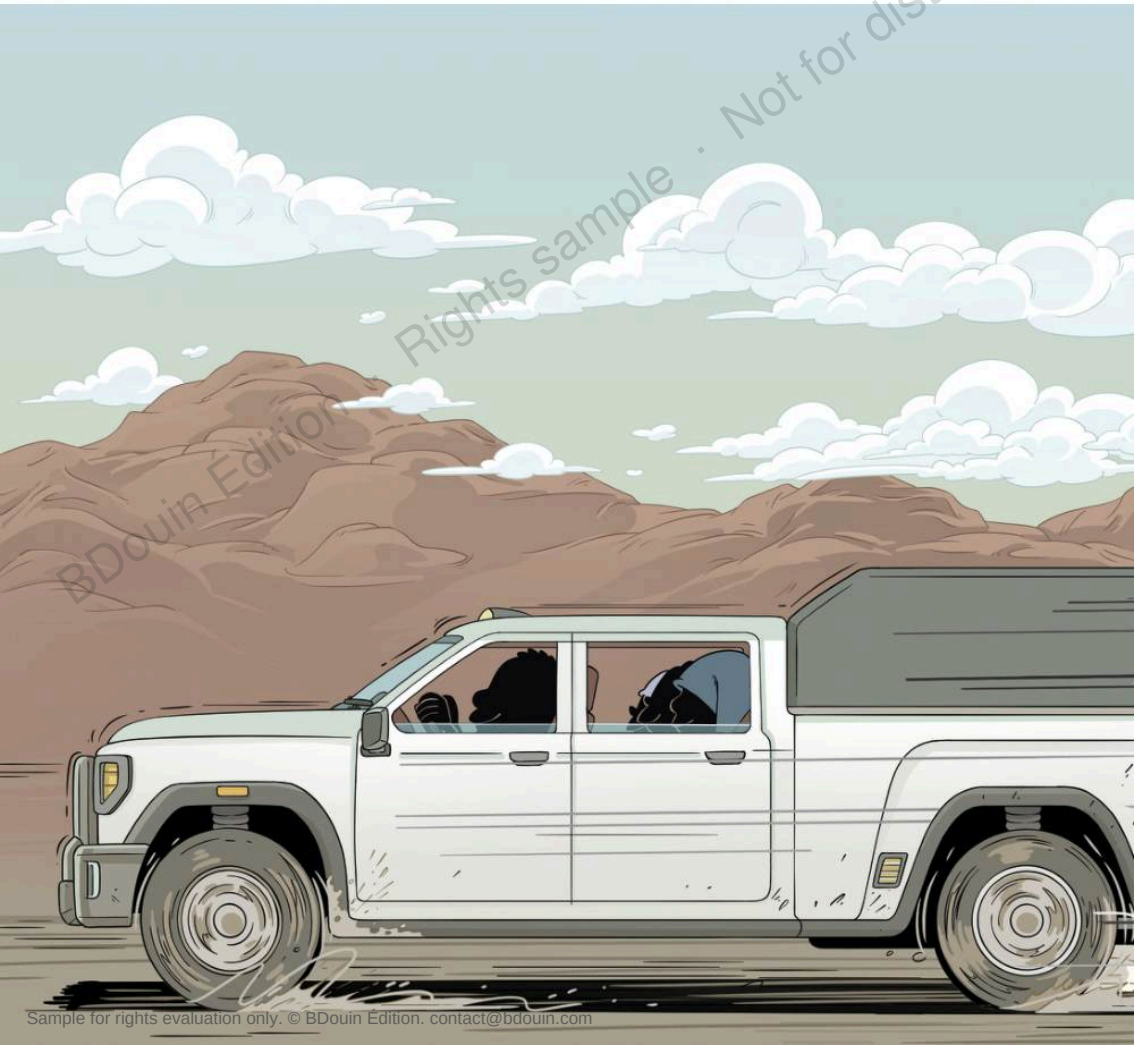
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We've been driving for about an hour on the long, quiet road towards Mecca. The car was filled with a mix of peaceful silence and the lively chants of the Talbiyah, perfectly matching the endless desert stretching out beyond the tinted windows.

Abi, always the playful one, kept things interesting. With a mischievous smile, he asked our guide questions about Umrah— questions we knew he already knew the answers to!

"So, it's absolutely forbidden to pluck even one single hair while in Ihram, right?" he asked, pretending to be shocked.



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"That's right!" our guide replied with a knowing smile. "Not even a rebellious hair! Ha ha!"

Me and Binti couldn't help but laugh, imagining a tiny hair trying to run away from a pilgrim's hands.

"And could you remind us of the main pillars of Umrah?" Abi asked, keeping the conversation going with his usual playful grin.



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"Of course!" answered our guide. "There are three main pillars: entering the state of Ihram, performing Tawaf around the Kaaba, and doing Sa'i between Safa and Marwa. And as for the obligations, there's shaving the head!"

"Shaving the head?!" Binti exclaimed. "Are we really going to shave our hair?!"

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"Oh no, Binti, don't worry!" Oummi intervened, reassuringly. "Shaving the head is only for men. We'll just trim a tiny bit of hair, about the length of a fingertip."



"Too bad! I would've loved to see you with a bald head!" I joked, teasing her.

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1. Hajja Amina

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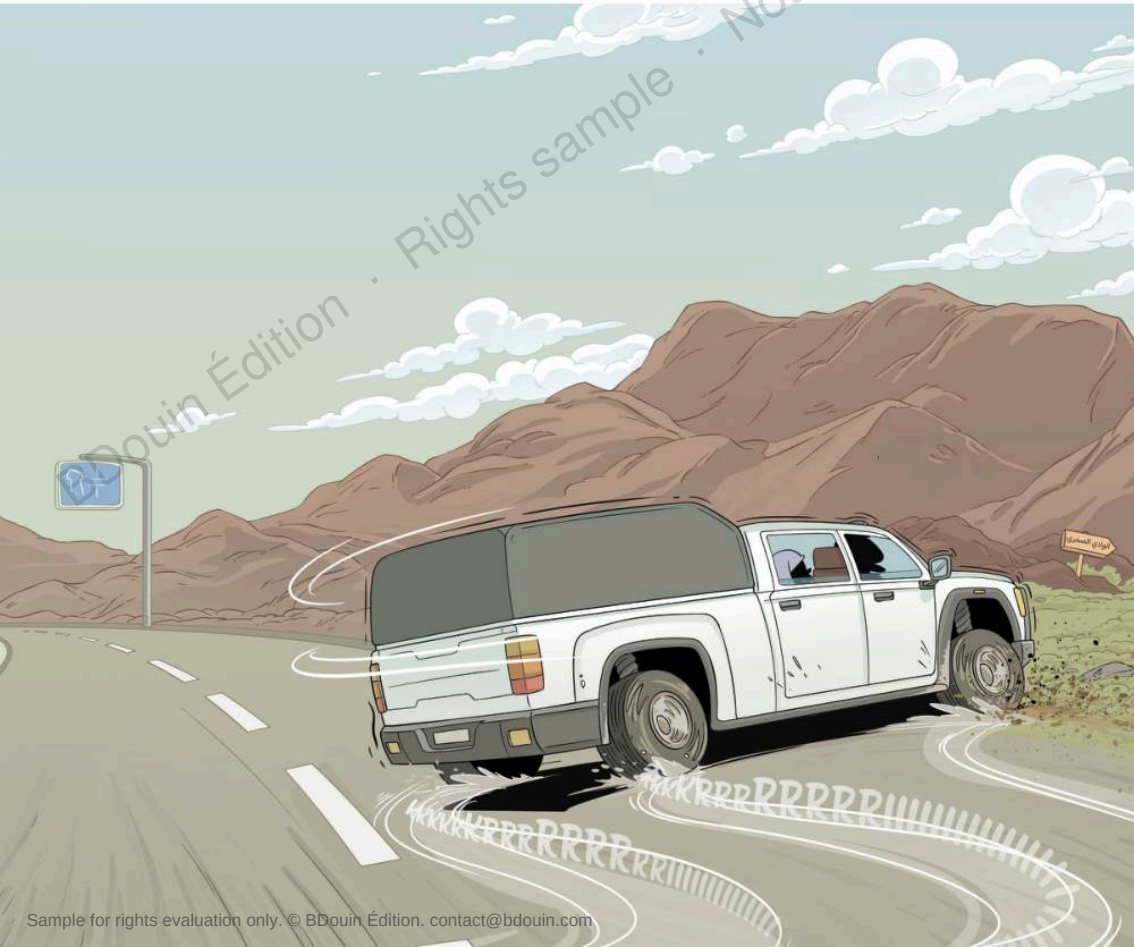
Around Dhuhr, the noon prayer, Abou Layla suggested an unexpected lunch stop.

"I know an amazing place to eat just a few minutes off the main road," he said enthusiastically. "If you're up for it, we could make a quick stop."

Abi noticed the curiosity in Oummi's eyes and agreed right away. "Sounds great! It'll give us a chance to stretch our legs and pray. Which way do we go?"

"This way!" Abou Layla exclaimed, turning sharply to the right and taking us off-road, heading towards the rocky valleys.

This guide was truly unpredictable!



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After a few minutes of bumping along rough paths, the road finally smoothed out. Then, as we passed a few hills that had blocked our view, we were stunned by the sight before us!

We had entered a completely different landscape, with wide rivers flowing through lush greenery stretching as far as the eye could see.



"Masha'Allah!" Abi exclaimed. "How is this possible?"

"It's the middle of the rainy season in Quba, as you've probably noticed," our guide explained with a chuckle. "The landscapes of Arabia transform completely during this time."

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A few minutes later, we reached a dirt road that twisted through some surprisingly green plants and trees. At the base of a big old tree, we stopped at the place Abou Layla had been so eager to show us.

"Welcome to Hajja Amina's little restaurant!" he said, grinning with excitement.



Believe it or not, this so-called "restaurant" was actually a small caravan, set up in authentic Arab style! Tents were pitched on either side, with numerous decorative items hanging from the outside.

Abou Layla parked the car under a tree and invited us to settle into a cozy open-air lounge area, laid out on the ground in traditional traditional majlis style.

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There were several of these seating areas scattered across the field, spaced far enough apart to give everyone some privacy.

"I'm completely charmed," Oummi murmured, admiring the table setting, which had been arranged with such attention to detail.

From a distance, we could see our guide engaged in a deep conversation with an elderly woman, who we assumed was the head chef. It seemed she was running this entire place on her own. Soon, he returned, balancing a large tray of fruit on his head.

"Here's a little starter while we wait for the main course!" he said cheerfully.



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With a respectful gesture, he placed the tray down for our parents, took a small portion for himself, and then moved to another spot, giving us the chance to enjoy the moment in complete privacy.

"Masha'Allah! This watermelon is amazing!" Binti exclaimed, biting into a juicy piece.

"And these dates! Wow!" Abi added.

We were savoring the delicious snack when the elderly woman appeared, pushing a metal cart towards us.

"Assalam'Alaykum, Foulane family! Ahlan, Ahlan!" she greeted us joyfully.



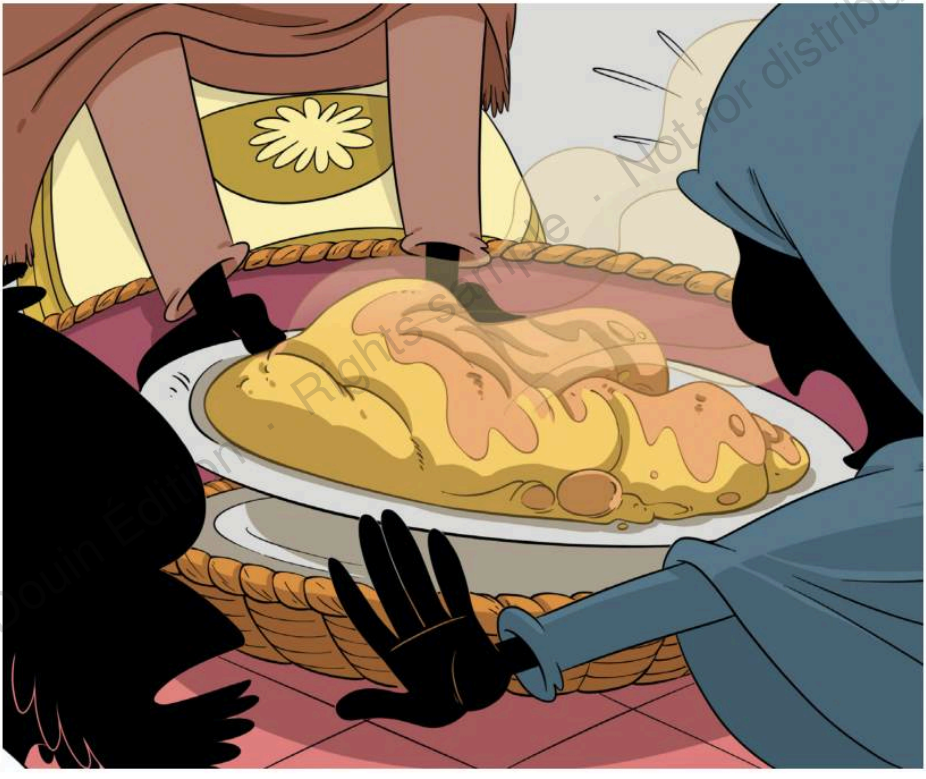
"Wa'Alaykum Salam wa rahmatullah, Ya Hajja!" Oummi responded, just as joyful. "Ahlan wa sahlan!"

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Focused on her task, Hajja opened the bottom of her cart and revealed an incredible tray of roasted meat, which she carefully placed on our low table.

Oummi's eyes instantly lit up at the sight of the dish, and without a second thought, she pulled out her phone.

"Don't touch anything!" she exclaimed. "I absolutely have to take a picture! The WHOLE WORLD needs to see this culinary masterpiece!"



While Oummi snapped photos from every possible angle, Abi seized the moment to ask the elderly woman if she had any bread.

"Al Khobz? Ha ha!" she responded, amused by the question.

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She then reopened her cart, pulled out a small gas canister with a round metal tray on top, and, with a confident motion, lit it. Grabbing a plastic bottle filled with liquid dough, she poured it onto the tray, skillfully forming small, circular breads.



When Oummi saw this, she became even more excited.

"Am I dreaming, or is she making traditional bread right on the tray? This is incredible! This Hajja should be part of UNESCO's world heritage list!"

And so, we enjoyed what would become one of the most unforgettable meals of our lives!

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A few minutes later, I saw Abou Layla waving his arms at me like he was stranded on a deserted island. Curious, I walked over to him.

"Follow me for a moment, you'll see..." he whispered, his voice full of mystery.

We pushed through some thick bushes that had been hiding the view, and then I saw it.

"Wait... A VOLCANO?! Seriously?!" I shouted, completely shocked.



"Absolutely! Ha ha! It's called a 'baby volcano,' a small, inactive volcano," said Abou Layla.

"But... there are volcanoes in Saudi Arabia?" I asked.

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"Oh yes, and some really big ones! There are over 2,500 of them in the country." he explained.

"Wait here!" I said excitedly. "I have to show this to Binti!" So I rushed back to my family, excited to bring them to see this incredible natural wonder. They were just as amazed as I was. Once again, Abou Layla showed us why he's the best guide ever!



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2. Animal Danger

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